

EG Global Macro, Aerospace & Defense: NATO's summit mixes repackaged deals with real new commitments

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Global Macro, Aerospace & Defense

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NATO's summit mixes repackaged deals with real new commitments

* This year's NATO summit produced a flurry of defense announcements, but several of the most prominent deals repackaged existing commitments or incremental progress on programs already underway.

* European member states were eager to demonstrate their increased defense spending to the US, allowing President Donald Trump to claim a win for US firms in intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance (ISR), missiles, and munitions orders.

* Equally important as the new orders, NATO's new industrial policy tools should reduce uncertainty for suppliers and channel private capital into capacity and critical inputs.

Defense deals are the big headline from the summit, but context is essential. While some of the deals represent genuinely new commitments that will bolster NATO's industrial base, others represent incremental progress on programs already well underway, and some may ultimately prove to be stymied as frameworks or aspirational political promises. Some of the projects that NATO allies presented included: Triton ISR drones (new), GlobalEye AWACS replacements (recent), A400M airlift (existing program), A330 MRTT tankers (existing program), a \$40 billion Drone Edge counter-drone initiative (new), a standardized 155-millimeter artillery round, and multiple missile stockpile and maintenance schemes. These complement broader industrial initiatives aimed at converting higher defense spending into lasting production capacity and more resilient supply chains. The announcements demonstrate that NATO is looking to bolster its core combat support capabilities, especially real-time intelligence gathering and logistical capabilities.

Trump can claim wins for US suppliers on ISR, missiles, and munitions. Some repackaged recent announcements favored European primes: Saab secured a high-visibility AWACS replacement, and TKMS captured what Ottawa calls the largest procurement in Canadian history. However, US primes still dominate the missile and munitions segment. Key interest focused on RTX/Raytheon for Stinger and AMRAAM, Lockheed Martin for PAC-3 and ATACMS, and Northrop Grumman for Triton ISR. While there

is a growing preference for domestic European procurement where possible, the US defense industry remains a critical piece of NATO procurement.

Funding certainty is highest for aircraft, drones, and missile deals. The announcements vary considerably in terms of firm financial commitments—including a combination of both existing funding and new sales—while some are still in the discussion or study phase and nowhere near a funding commitment. NATO's European members and Canada have already added roughly \$90 billion to defense spending in real terms in 2025 versus 2024, and 2025–2026 outlays are about \$258 billion above prior baselines.

The deals most likely to advance are ISR, air-mobility programs, and the counter-drone package. Denmark, Finland, Germany, and Norway have signed letters of intent to jointly acquire up to five MQ-4C Tritons to supplement NATO's RQ-4D fleet; once post-sale training and servicing are included, the total package should exceed \$10 billion. Pre-summit, allies also opened formal talks with Saab to procure up to ten GlobalEye aircraft, valued at \$4.5 billion, to replace aging Boeing E-3A AWACS platforms. The TKMS award for up to 12 Canadian submarines, announced just prior to Prime Minister Carney's travel to Ankara, is signed but not yet priced. By contrast, many of the other announcements repackage previously committed programs or reiterate memorandums of understanding and statements of intent. For example, both the A400M transport aircraft and A330 MRTT tanker aircraft are decades-old Airbus programs—neither announcement marks significant new industrial activity.

Not all Ankara headlines will translate into firm orders or immediate action. Trump's suggestion that he may consider readmitting Turkey to the F-35 program and his pledge to license Patriot missile production in Ukraine are politically significant, but face legislative, export-control, and alliance-management hurdles. Certification to move forward with F-35 sales falls to the Department of Defense and the State Department. Trump's announcement is likely to face significant bipartisan congressional opposition. And while Trump's pledge to co-produce Patriot missiles in Ukraine is viewed positively by NATO partners, it will have minimal strategic impact in the short to medium term.

Surveillance system and drone investments support a threat assessment still centered on Russia. Triton and GlobalEye are designed to close ISR gaps on NATO's eastern and northern flanks, offering maritime surveillance and multi-domain early warning against Russia. The Tritons will also allow sustained operational activity across other theaters, including NATO's high north and Arctic regions. The \$40 billion Drone Edge initiative and the plan to increase fivefold the number of trained drone operators by 2027 draw explicitly on lessons from the Ukraine and Iran wars. The Stinger, AMRAAM, PAC-3, and ATACMS initiatives address depleted missile stockpiles.

Financing and policy innovations may be the most consequential for markets. The NATO Front Door for Industry will, for the first time, publish an unclassified summary of allied capability requirements—giving suppliers clearer visibility into what governments need and are prepared to procure. The Engine Initiative aims to match spare industrial capacity with production needs, encouraging civilian manufacturing firms to diversify into defense production. A "Call to Action" to financial institutions and a joint critical raw-materials initiative seek to mobilize private capital and secure supply chains, while the UK and Canada's move to align defense-financing mechanisms hints at future standardization of lending and co-investment structures.

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